The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra, the Dhāraṇī Called "The Casket of Secret Relics, the Essence of the Blessing of All Tathāgatas"

Āryasarvatathāgatādhiṣṭhānahṛdayaguhyadhātukaraṇḍanāmadhāraṇīmahāyānasūtra · Toh 883 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་དེ་བཞིན་གཤེགས་པ་ཐམས་ཅད་ཀྱི་བྱིན་གྱིས་བརླབས་ཀྱི་སྙིང་པོ་གོསང་བ་རིང་བསྲེལ་གྱི་ཟ་མ་ཏོག་ཅེས་བྱ་བ་ཐེག་པ་ཆེན་པོའི་མདོ།

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra, the Dhāraṇī Called "The Casket of Secret Relics, the Essence of the Blessing of All Tathāgatas," known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Sarvatathāgatādhiṣṭhānahṛdayaguhyadhātukaraṇḍa Nāma Dhāraṇī Mahāyāna Sūtra and in Tibetan as Phags pa de bzhin gshegs pa thams cad kyi byin gyis brlabs kyi snying po gsang ba ring bsrel gyi za ma tog ces bya ba'i gzungs theg pa chen po'i mdo, is a Mahāyāna dhāraṇī scripture. It opens in the land of Magadha, where the Buddha dwells in the Stainless Park beside a pool made of the seven precious substances. He is surrounded by bodhisattvas, śrāvakas, and countless gods, nāgas, and other beings, as well as the people of that land, and a great brahmin in the assembly sets the teaching in motion. The text centers on the sacred power of relics and the blessing of all the tathāgatas, and it presents a dhāraṇī long associated with consecrating stūpas and the merit of honoring them. It is Toh 883 in the Kangyur, where it belongs among the dhāraṇī texts.

In the language of India: ārya sarbatathāgata adhiṣṭhāna hṛdaya guhya dhātu karaṇḍa nāma dhāraṇī mahāyāna sūtra

In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra, the Dhāraṇī Called "The Casket of Secret Relics, the Essence of the Blessing of All Tathāgatas."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling in the land of Magadha, in the Stainless Park, at a pool made of the seven precious substances. He was surrounded and attended by a great saṅgha of bodhisattvas, a great saṅgha of śrāvakas, and many tens of millions of gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, great mahoragas, humans, and nonhumans, as well as many hundreds of thousands of the people of that land.

Now in that assembly there was a great brahmin, like a great sāla tree, named Stainless Excellent Light. He was learned, wise, bright, and keen-minded, a

delight to behold, and he upheld the path of the ten virtuous actions. He had single-minded faith in the Three Jewels and the virtuous intention to revere them and pay them homage. He examined things closely, and he strove for the benefit of all sentient beings and for virtue. He had great wealth and great means; he was rich, with many possessions and abundant goods.

Then the great brahmin Stainless Excellent Light went to where the Blessed One was. When he arrived, he circumambulated the Blessed One seven times and made offerings to him of flowers and incense. He also presented him with robes worth a hundred thousand, and a pearl necklace worth a hundred thousand. Then he bowed his head at his feet, sat down before the Blessed One, and said to him, "Blessed One, I invite the Blessed One, together with his retinue of spiritual sons, to my home for the midday meal. Would the Blessed One please grant this?"

The Blessed One, understanding that the great brahmin Stainless Excellent Light had invited him, consented by remaining silent. The great brahmin Stainless Excellent Light, knowing from the Blessed One's silence that he had consented, hurried back to his own house. When that night had passed, he set out food and provisions, many dishes of a hundred flavors, and with great display he took up an auspicious celestial palace, various great celestial palaces, flowers, and incense. With a large retinue, with cymbals and drums sounding, he went to where the Blessed One was, and on arriving announced to the Blessed One that the time had come.

Then the great brahmin Stainless Excellent Light said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, it is now time to go. If the moment for the Blessed One to set out has arrived, would you please grant my request?"

Then the Blessed One, having reassured the great brahmin Stainless Excellent Light, looked at his own retinue and said, "All of you who have gathered in this assembly, today a great benefit will be accomplished. Come along!"

Then the Blessed One rose from his seat. The very moment the Blessed One rose from his seat, many different light rays came forth from his body. The radiance of those light rays illuminated all the buddhafields of the ten directions, and roused all the tathāgatas, who looked and knew that he was setting out.

Then the great brahmin Stainless Excellent Light worshipped him with offerings and great honor, and richly adorned the way along which the Blessed One went. The large retinue, the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras,

garuḍas, kinnaras, and great mahoragas, and Śakra (Indra), Brahmā, the world protectors, Maheśvara (Śiva), Nārāyaṇa, and the Four Great Kings also adorned the way along which he went.

Now, not at all far from the Blessed One, somewhere along the way, there was a pleasure garden called Bliss-Maker. In that garden stood a great old stupa. It had collapsed and was full of thorns, completely overgrown with grass and trees and filled with rubble, so that it looked like a heap of rubbish.

When the Blessed One drew near to it, that old stupa that looked like a heap of rubbish blazed all over, and blazing light rays of many colors shone forth from it. From that heap of rubbish and rubble a voice also came forth, saying, "Excellent! Excellent, Tathāgata Śākyamuni! Today your coming is an auspicious sign. Great brahmin, you too have done well in inviting the Tathāgata. Today a great benefit will be accomplished for you."

Then the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, prostrated with the five limbs to that old stupa that looked like a heap of rubbish and circumambulated it three times. He took the robe from his own body and placed it upon that old stupa that looked like a heap of rubbish. The Blessed One shed a great flood of tears and wept, and then the Blessed One smiled. Through that smile all the tathāgatas of the ten directions were seen as clearly as if they were resting in the palm of one's hand. All those tathāgatas, too, sat with their eyes full of tears. And all those tathāgatas also sent forth light rays, which entered that great heap of the old stupa.

Then the great assembly gathered there was struck with great amazement, and they sat there dismayed. Then the great general of the yakṣas, Vajrapāṇi, his body trembling, his heart shaken, brandishing his vajra, hurried to where the Blessed One was. On arriving, he bowed his head at the Blessed One's feet and said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, there is this great portent of the Blessed One weeping. What is its cause? Blessed One, what is this portent in which the Blessed One shows his eyes filled with tears? Why is this so? Will the Blessed One grant me an opening to ask this question here in this assembly?"

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to the great general of the yakṣas, Vajrapāṇi: "Vajrapāṇi, this heap of relics is a stupa of the Tathāgata. In it is the Dharma discourse of the stupa of the mudrā of the dhāraṇī that is the essence of all ten million tathāgatas, as numerous as sesame seeds in a pod. Vajrapāṇi, wherever this Dharma discourse is present, there dwell hundreds of thousands

of millions of tathāgatas, as numerous as sesame seeds in a pod, and there are present the bodily relics of tathāgatas as numerous as what is called 'beyond measure upon beyond measure.' There are present the eighty-four thousand heaps of the Dharma. The crown protuberances and the crowns of the heads of ninety-nine hundreds of thousands of millions of tathāgatas, as numerous as sesame seeds in a pod, are likewise present there. Vajrapāṇi, wherever this Dharma discourse is present, that place is declared to be a stupa of the Tathāgata. Vajrapāṇi, this Dharma discourse is thus of great benefit and great power. Vajrapāṇi, this Dharma discourse is of great benefit. Vajrapāṇi, this Dharma discourse brings all auspiciousness to perfection."

Then the great assembly gathered there, having heard this Dharma discourse from the Blessed One, obtained the Dharma eye regarding phenomena, free of dust and free of stain, and then were freed from the secondary afflictions. Some attained the fruit of stream-entry. Some attained arhatship. Some attained the fruit of solitary awakening. Some attained the fruit of non-returning. Some attained the fruit of once-returning. Some came to abide on a bodhisattva ground. Some obtained the prophecy of awakening. Some attained the first ground. Some the second ground. Some the third ground. Some the fourth ground. Some the fifth ground. Some the sixth ground. Some the seventh ground. Some the eighth ground. Some the ninth ground. Some came to abide on the tenth ground. Some brought the six perfections to completion. The great brahmin, too, obtained the five superknowledges, became free of stain, and became free of miserliness and jealousy.

The great general of the yakṣas, Vajrapāṇi, having seen such a great miracle, was struck with great wonder and amazement, and said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if even by hearing the name of this Dharma discourse one obtains such an adornment of beneficial qualities, then, Blessed One, what need is there to speak of one who makes offerings and shows it abundant honor? Blessed One, what kind of heap of merit will such a person come to see?"

The Blessed One said: "Listen, Vajrapāṇi. Whatever son of noble family or daughter of noble family, monk or nun, layman or laywoman writes out this Dharma discourse, Vajrapāṇi, that person will come to possess the heap of merit and the generation of roots of virtue of ninety-nine hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of tathāgatas, as numerous as sesame seeds in a pod, and will be cared for by those tathāgatas. Those who recite it will also come to hold the sūtras spoken by the tathāgatas. Those who hold such a

Dharma discourse will be held in care by the ninety-nine hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of tathāgatas of the ten directions, as numerous as sesame seeds in a pod, and by the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas of each direction, and will be watched over by them every single day.

"The son of noble family or daughter of noble family, the layman or laywoman who makes offerings to this Dharma discourse, who comprehends it, and who makes offerings to it with flowers, incense, scents, garlands, unguents, garments, streamers, and ornaments, will thereby be making offerings with divine flowers, incense, scents, garlands, unguents, garments, streamers, and ornaments to the ninety-nine hundreds of thousands of millions of billions of tathāgatas, as numerous as sesame seeds in a pod, of the ten directions and of each direction. For each tathāgata of each direction, there will arise the merit of clouds of tathāgata offerings, heaps as vast as great Mount Meru, made of the seven precious substances."

Then the gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans and nonhumans, and that great host of sentient beings were also amazed, and said to one another, "This old stupa, a heap of rubbish and rubble, has been blessed by the blessing of the Tathāgata, and since it displays a great miracle of magical power, it is of great might."

Then the great general of the yakṣas, Vajrapāṇi, said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, who has made this, which had become a heap of rubbish, appear as a precious stupa?"

The Blessed One said: "Vajrapāṇi, this is not a heap of rubbish. This is a great precious stupa made of the seven precious substances. Vajrapāṇi, however, because it displays the ripening of the karmic results of sentient beings, it has become hidden. The stupas of the relic essence of the tathāgatas, the buddhas, do not perish or fall apart. How could the vajra-essence body of the Tathāgata fall apart? Yet because of the appearance of the ripening of beings' karmic results, it has become hidden."

"Furthermore, Vajrapāṇi, in a later time, in a future age, there will arise in very great numbers those who engage in evil of every kind, those who are wicked, and those bent on hell. They will not seek the Buddha, they will not seek the Dharma, they will not seek the Saṅgha, and they will not themselves cultivate roots of virtue. Through that cause and that condition the true Dharma will decline. Vajrapāṇi, that is why my two eyes are filled with tears, and why all

the Tathāgatas, too, have shed tears. A discourse of the true Dharma such as this will decline, except within the stūpas of the Tathāgatas, for those will be blessed by all the Tathāgatas."

Then Vajrapāṇi, the great general of the yakṣas, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, if someone writes out this Dharma discourse and places it inside a stūpa, what root of virtue will arise?"

The Blessed One said: "Vajrapāṇi, whoever writes out this Dharma discourse and places it inside a stūpa, that stūpa will become a stūpa of the relics of the vajra essence of all the Tathāgatas. It will become a stūpa blessed by the secret essence of the dhāraṇī of all the Tathāgatas. It will become a stūpa of tathāgatas as numerous as the seeds of ninety-nine sesame pods. It will be blessed as a stūpa of the uṣṇīṣa and the eyes of all the Tathāgatas. If someone places it inside a buddha image or inside any stūpa, that image of the Tathāgata will be blessed as having the nature of the seven precious substances. Its garland of wheels, joined with nets of bells and small bells, and its auspicious emblems and the form of its rain canopy, together with its bells, will be blessed as having the nature of the seven precious substances. Through the power, the blessing, the truth, and the sacred commitment of all the Tathāgatas and of this Dharma discourse, it will be blessed until the very heart of awakening is reached.

"Whatever sentient beings pay homage and show veneration to that stūpa will certainly become irreversible, and will fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. Through a single prostration and a single circumambulation they will be completely liberated from the hells down to Avīci and the rest, and will become irreversible from unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"In whatever place such a stūpa or image stands, that locality will be blessed by all the Tathāgatas. In that region untamed nāgas will be unable to do harm. Frost and hail will be unable to do harm. In that place untamed or vicious creatures will be unable to do harm. Beasts of prey will be unable to do harm. There will be no danger from untamed birds, parrots, mynas, rats, weasels, gadflies, flies, locusts, three-jawed bees, mosquitoes, or horseflies. Venomous snakes will be unable to do harm.

"In that region there will be no epidemic disease, no contagion, and no strife. There will be no danger from yakṣas, rākṣasas, bhūtas, pretas, demons, or apasmāras. No graha whatsoever will be able to do harm. No fever whatsoever

will be able to do harm. No disease of any kind, no tumors, blisters, ulcers, fistulas, sores of the feet, itch, or leprosy will be able to do harm, and merely by seeing that stūpa all of them will be cured. In that region no disease of cattle, no disease of livestock, no disease of the many other kinds of animal birth, and no disease of men, women, boys, or girls will ever be able to do harm. No one will die an untimely death. Neither poison nor weapons, nor fire and water, will ever be able to do harm. Neither the threat of enemy armies nor the threat of famine will ever be able to do harm. There will be no threat from the army of a great king.

"The Four Great Kings will constantly and unceasingly protect and guard that locality. Those twenty-eight great generals of the yakṣas will also constantly and unceasingly protect, defend, and shelter it. The twenty-eight lunar mansions, the moon, the sun, and the great comet will be favorable day and night. All the nāga kings will constantly and unceasingly refrain from stealing its vitality, and will send down streams of rain only in beneficial measure. All the gods will come from the thirty-two abodes three times a day in order to bow down, to show honor, and to make offerings to that great stūpa. All who dwell in the land will come to that stūpa and image three times a day; they will praise it and circumambulate it. Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, together with the goddesses and the hosts of gods, will unceasingly come before that stūpa or image three times each day and night, and will come to bow down and to make offerings. All the Tathāgatas, too, constantly keep it in mind and bless it, and abide there.

"Whatever kind of stūpa or image one makes, whether of clay, stone, wood, silver, gold, or copper, if one also writes out this Dharma discourse and places it inside, then the very moment it is placed there it will be blessed as having the nature of the seven precious substances. Its terraces, steps, railings, garland of wheels, auspicious emblems, parasol, hanging bells, banners, and nets of bells and small bells will all come to have the nature of the seven precious substances. On all four sides, images of the Tathāgata will be present. It will become a precious stūpa blessed with the blessing of all the Tathāgatas, a stūpa of the essence of relics, and a shrine worthy of worship. That image and stūpa will be protected by the gods of the abode of Akaniṣṭha and embraced with their offerings."

Then Vajrapāṇi, the great general of the yakṣas, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how does this Dharma discourse come to have such special qualities?"

The Blessed One said: "It is the dhāraṇī of the mudrā of the secret relic casket, the essence of the blessing of all the tathāgatas. Therefore, Vajrapāṇi, this power has been blessed by blessing to have such special qualities."

Vajradhara said: "Blessed One, please be so kind as to explain the Dharma discourse of the dhāraṇī of the mudrā of the jewel casket."

The Blessed One said: "Vajrapāṇi, listen! The tathāgata bodies of all the tathāgatas of the past, of the future and of the present, and of all the buddhas, the blessed ones, who have passed into complete nirvāṇa, are three: the dharma body, the enjoyment body, and likewise the emanation body. This is the Dharma discourse of the dhāraṇī of the mudrā of the relic casket of all those of the three times."

namastraiyadhvikānāṃ sarvatathāgatānāṃ oṃ bhuvibhavānavare vacaṭau culu culu dhare dhare sarvatathāgata dhātudhare padmagarbhe jayavare acale smaratathāgata dharmmacakra pravarttana vajrabodhimaṇḍa alaṃkāra alaṃkṛte sarvatathāgata adhiṣṭhite bodhaya bodhaya bodhani bodhani buddhaya buddhaya saṃbodhani saṃbodhaya cala cala calaṃtu sarva āvaraṇāni sarva pāpaṃ vigate huru huru sarva śoka vikate sarvatathāgatahṛdaya vajriṇi saṃbhava saṃbhava sarvatathāgataguhye dhāraṇi mudre buddhe subuddha sarvatathāgata adhiṣṭhite dhātugarbhe svāhā samaya adhiṣṭhite svāhā sarvatathāgatahṛdaya dhātumudre svāhā supratiṣṭhita stuve tathāgata adhiṣṭhite hūṃ hūṃ svāhā oṃ sarvatathāgata uṣṇīṣa dhātumudrāṇi sarvatathāgata dharmadhātu vibhuṣita adhiṣṭhite huru huru hūṃ hūṃ svāhā

As soon as the Blessed One had spoken this dhāraṇī of the mudrā of the relic casket, tathāgatas came from the ten directions and from every single direction. There were ninety-nine hundred thousand koṭis of trillions of them, as many as the seeds that fill a sesame pod. They gave their approval to the Blessed One Śākyamuni, saying: "Excellent, excellent, that Śākyamuni, for the sake of all sentient beings, has placed in Jambudvīpa such a Dharma discourse as this as a treasure of the Dharma, and has blessed the stūpa of the essence of the relics! This is the commitment and the blessing of all the tathāgatas. Wherever this dhāraṇī of the relic mudrā is taught, or placed inside a stūpa, or placed inside an image, there all the tathāgatas will follow and dwell as one, always and without interruption. Everywhere it will be blessed with the blessing of the tathāgatas."

Then, the moment the dhāraṇī had been spoken, that old stūpa, which had been like a heap of rubbish, rose up as a stūpa made of the seven precious substances. It now had its tiers, its beautifully spreading form, its garland of wheels, and its auspicious ornaments.

The Blessed One, pleased, spoke thus. Then the bodhisattva great being Vajrapāṇi, and those gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, garuḍas, kinnaras and mahoragas, and the world with its gods and humans, rejoiced in what the Blessed One had said and praised it.

This completes the noble Great Vehicle sūtra, the dhāraṇī called The Secret Relic Casket, Essence of the Blessing of All Tathāgatas.

It was translated, edited and finalized by the Indian preceptor Vidyākaraprabha and the chief editor and translator, the monk Tsang Devendrarakṣita.

Translator's Notes

• The brahmin's name, the park's name and the garden's name are translated literally ("Stainless Excellent Light," "Stainless Park," "Bliss-Maker"), because their Sanskrit forms could not be identified with confidence. The word sdum pa in the invitation is unclear. It is rendered "my home" from context, since it is an invitation to a midday meal.
• The expression rendered "beyond measure upon beyond measure" may be the Tibetan rendering of an Indian numeral term for a vast count. Its exact value is uncertain, so it is translated by its sense. In Vajrapāṇi's second question, the Tibetan could also be read as "Who turned this precious stupa into a heap of rubbish?" The reading chosen takes it as asking who made it appear as a stupa again. The Tibetan reads 'dri ba ("to ask") in the first benefit. Following the sequence write, recite, hold, offer, which is standard in this dhāraṇī and its Sanskrit parallels (likhati), it is taken as a variant spelling of 'bri ba ("to write").
• The phrase rendered "tathāgatas as numerous as the seeds of ninety-nine sesame pods" is literally "tathāgatas as many as a sesame pod, ninety-nine"; the parallel Chinese version reads "ninety-nine hundred thousand koṭis of tathāgatas, like sesame seeds," so the exact construction is uncertain. Several architectural terms for parts of the stūpa (rendered "terraces" and "railings") and some names of pests in the list (such as "locusts" and "three-jawed bees") are uncertain identifications.
• The number of tathāgatas combines several large units: hundred thousand, koṭi, and a further unit usually equated with a niyuta. "Koṭis of trillions" approximates this. The architectural terms describing the restored stūpa are rendered approximately: its tiers, its spreading form, and its garland of wheels, which are probably the stacked parasol rings. Vajradhara here is an epithet of Vajrapāṇi.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.